

# ARCHITECTURE FOUNDATIONS AND HARAPPAN URBANISM

Rapid revision master flow: timeline -> core architecture -> evidence limits -> 2025 answer route

00

## HOW TO READ THE TOPIC

### CORE EVIDENCE

Start with excavated form: grid, brick, drains, baths, platforms and reservoirs.

### WHY IT MATTERS

This method keeps the answer evidence-bound and architecture-first.

### LIMIT / TRAP

Do not let script speculation replace built evidence.

WRITE THE ANSWER THIS WAY: START WITH EXCAVATED FORM, THEN MOVE TO BOUNDED INFERENCE.

01

## ORIGIN AND TIMELINE RAIL

### CORE EVIDENCE

Early foundations -> Mature Urban peak -> Late/Post-Urban change.  
1853 Cunningham seal notice -> 1921 Harappa excavation -> 1922 Mohenjo-daro excavation -> 1931 Marshall major excavation report  
1968 Dholavira discovery -> 1989-2005 excavation seasons -> 2021 UNESCO inscription -> 2025 direct GS-1 PYQ

### WHY IT MATTERS

This separates the civilisation timeline from modern recovery and heritage history.

### LIMIT / TRAP

Do not merge excavation dates or UNESCO dates into Harappan phase chronology.

WRITE THE ANSWER THIS WAY: PHASE HISTORY AND DISCOVERY HISTORY MUST BE KEPT DISTINCT.

02

## VOCABULARY AND BUILDING CLASSES

### CORE EVIDENCE

Dwelling houses; public buildings; public baths.  
Citadel and lower town are the core structural terms.

### WHY IT MATTERS

Classification prevents the answer from shrinking into one monument or one site.

### LIMIT / TRAP

Topic 1 owns built form and evidence limits, not full political chronology.

WRITE THE ANSWER THIS WAY: HOUSES + PUBLIC STRUCTURES + CIVIC WATER WORKS = THE HARAPPAN PACKAGE.

03

## GRID AND TWO-PART SETTLEMENT

### CORE EVIDENCE

Right-angled streets show pre-planning.  
Citadel = raised public zone; lower town = larger residential area.

### WHY IT MATTERS

This is the first strong proof of civic planning and functional zoning.

### LIMIT / TRAP

Use functional zoning; do not infer a fixed caste map or one exact constitution.

WRITE THE ANSWER THIS WAY: RIGHT-ANGLED STREETS AND ZONED SETTLEMENT REVEAL PRE-PLANNED URBAN ORDER.

04

## MATERIAL, HOUSES AND WATER INSIDE THE HOME

### CORE EVIDENCE

Standardised baked-brick proportions; specialised waterproofing at the Great Bath.  
Private wells, designated bathing areas, some stairways.

### WHY IT MATTERS

Brick standardisation and domestic water design show repeatable technical norms.

### LIMIT / TRAP

Do not generalise technical mortar language across all Harappan construction.

WRITE THE ANSWER THIS WAY: STANDARDISED BAKED BRICK + CONTEXT-SPECIFIC CONSTRUCTION.

05

## DRAINAGE AS CIVIC ENGINEERING

### CORE EVIDENCE

House drain -> covered street drain -> cleaning point / cesspit.

### WHY IT MATTERS

The system links household water use to citywide maintenance and hygiene.

### LIMIT / TRAP

Stress connection and maintainability, not just the existence of covered drains.

WRITE THE ANSWER THIS WAY: HARAPPAN DRAINAGE IS NETWORKED, MAINTAINABLE CIVIC ENGINEERING.

06

## PUBLIC STRUCTURES AND LABEL CAUTION

### CORE EVIDENCE

Great Bath = secure public water structure.  
Granary and dockyard = conventional archaeological labels.  
No confirmed palace or temple.

### WHY IT MATTERS

Naming caution itself earns marks because it shows evidence discipline.

### LIMIT / TRAP

Ritual cleansing is plausible, not inscriptionally confirmed; negative evidence is not absence of belief.

WRITE THE ANSWER THIS WAY: IMPRESSIVE PUBLIC WORKS, BUT FUNCTIONS AND INSTITUTIONS REMAIN PARTLY INFERENTIAL.

07

## REGIONAL ADAPTATION

### CORE EVIDENCE

Mohenjo-daro = bath and drains; Harappa = platforms; Dholavira = fortifications and reservoirs; Lothal = debated basin; Kalibangan = distinct planning.

### WHY IT MATTERS

The shared urban vocabulary survives ecological difference.

### LIMIT / TRAP

Do not project Mohenjo-daro mechanically onto every other site.

WRITE THE ANSWER THIS WAY: HARAPPAN STANDARDISATION OPERATED THROUGH REGIONAL ADAPTATION.

08

## EVIDENCE LADDER AND SCRIPT CEILING

### CORE EVIDENCE

Strong: grid, bricks, drains, baths, wells, reservoirs.  
Moderate: storage, labour coordination, differentiation.  
Unsupported: named king, confirmed temple, fixed caste, certain proto-Shiva.

### WHY IT MATTERS

The answer becomes sharper when claims are ranked by certainty.

### LIMIT / TRAP

Meluha and Pashupati are interpretive cautions, not licence for certainty.

WRITE THE ANSWER THIS WAY: HARAPPAN FORM PROVES PLANNING STRONGLY, CULT OR KINGSHIP ONLY WEAKLY.

09

## COMPARISON AND WATER FIREWALL

### CORE EVIDENCE

Harappan visible surplus = streets, drains, wells, baths, storage, reservoirs.  
Egypt / Mesopotamia = royal-sacred monumentality.  
Later stepwells / temple tanks / baulis belong to different contexts.

### WHY IT MATTERS

This converts description into a civilisational argument without false continuity.

### LIMIT / TRAP

Do not say absence of palace/temple means absence of power or religion; do not make later water forms direct descendants of drains.

WRITE THE ANSWER THIS WAY: DIFFERENT VISIBLE PRIORITY, NOT CULTURAL ABSENCE OR ONE UNBROKEN WATER LINEAGE.

10

## 2025 GS-1 ANSWER ROUTE

### CORE EVIDENCE

Open with grid -> move to zoning -> drainage -> baked-brick and domestic planning -> Dholavira -> caveat.

### WHY IT MATTERS

This order converts topic knowledge into a compact scoring answer.

### LIMIT / TRAP

Do not waste the 150 words on decline theory, random site lists or unsupported labels.

WRITE THE ANSWER THIS WAY: END WITH EVIDENTIARY CAUTION, NOT WITH OVERCONFIDENT SPECULATION.